

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 8

Mesopotamia

What Did People Do at Night?

✦ ✦ ✦

A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from the first cities to the last cuneiform tablet, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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The land of the two rivers

"Mesopotamia" is Greek for "between the rivers": the lands of the Tigris and the Euphrates, in today's Iraq and parts of Syria. In the flat south there was little stone or timber, so cities were built of mud brick and reed.



Ancient cities plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). The rivers and the coast of the Gulf have shifted a long way since antiquity; Ur and Eridu once lay much nearer the water.

Places you'll visit in the episode

Uruk: a true city by about 3500 BCE, framed in the epic by Gilgamesh's walls.

Eridu: one of the oldest cities of Sumer.

Nippur: holy city of Enlil, where a Sumerian lullaby was sung.

Sippar: city of the sun god, where a tablet of Gilgamesh with Siduri's advice was found.

Nimrud: Assyrian royal city excavated by Layard in the 1840s.

Ur: city of the moon god Nanna; its ziggurat was built by Ur-Nammu.

Girsu: in the state of Lagash, where Gudea dreamed of building the Eninnu.

Babylon: city of Hammurabi and Nebuchadnezzar II, with the Ishtar Gate.

Nineveh: Assyrian capital and home of Ashurbanipal's library; fell in 612 BCE.

Behistun: Darius I's rock inscription, a key to deciphering cuneiform.

THREE THOUSAND YEARS, SLOWLY

A timeline of the long nights



Early dates are approximate and follow the episode's sources.

c. 3500 BCE
Uruk has grown into a city.

c. 2500 BCE
Queen Puabi is buried at Ur with a gold and lapis drinking tube.

c. 2334–2279 BCE
Sargon of Akkad rules; his daughter Enheduanna serves the moon god at Ur.

c. 2125 BCE
Gudea of Lagash dreams of a temple and builds it.

c. 2112–2095 BCE
Ur-Nammu builds the ziggurat of Ur.

c. 1800 BCE
The Hymn to Ninkasi, goddess of beer, is written down.

c. 1750 BCE
The Yale culinary tablets record dozens of recipes, mostly broths.

1700s BCE
Hammurabi's laws include rules for tavern keepers.

c. 645 BCE
Ashurbanipal's "Garden Party" relief is carved at Nineveh.

c. 652 BCE
Babylonian Astronomical Diaries begin, kept until about 61 BCE.

612 BCE
Nineveh falls to the Babylonians and the Medes.

c. 575 BCE
Nebuchadnezzar II builds the Ishtar Gate.

539 BCE
Cyrus takes Babylon without destroying it.

323 BCE
Alexander the Great dies in Babylon.

c. 79/80 CE
The last datable cuneiform tablet, an astronomical almanac.

1840s–1850s
Layard and Hormuzd Rassam excavate Nineveh and Nimrud.

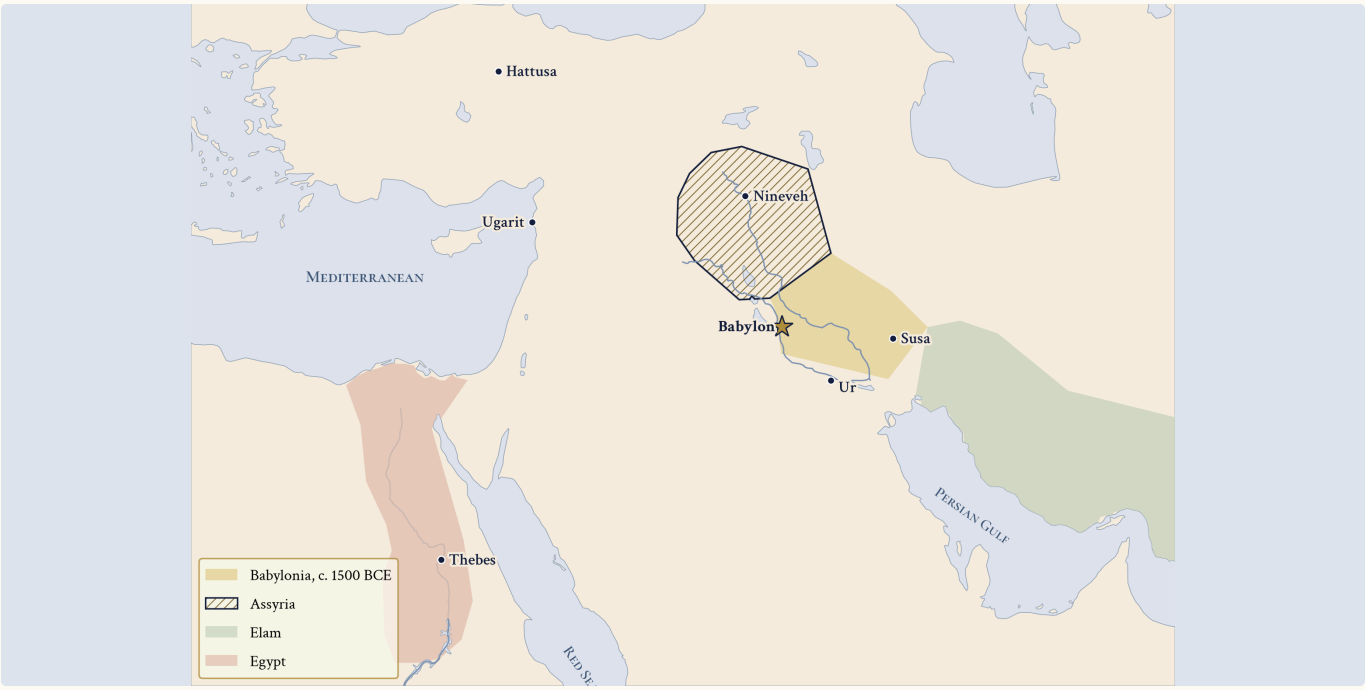
1872
George Smith reads the flood tablet of Gilgamesh.

1899–1917
Koldewey excavates Babylon.

1922–1934
Woolley excavates Ur.

2016
A tablet study shows Babylonians tracked Jupiter with geometry.

Kingdoms of the ancient Near East



Approximate extent of some of the great powers around 1500 BCE, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset; borders are approximate and changed many times over three thousand years. Ugarit, on the Syrian coast, is where the Hurrian hymn of about 1400 BCE was found.

People you'll meet

Puabi: queen of Ur around 2500 BCE, buried with lyres and gold.

Gudea: ruler of Lagash who dreamed of the temple Eninnu; Nanshe explained the dream.

Hammurabi: Babylonian king whose laws touched on taverns and break-ins.

Gilgamesh: legendary king of Uruk, hero of the epic, a dreamer of dreams.

Nebuchadnezzar II: builder of the Ishtar Gate and the Processional Way.

George Smith: British Museum scholar who read the flood story in 1872.

Enheduanna: daughter of Sargon, priestess of the moon god and poet of the Temple Hymns.

Ur-Nammu: king who built the ziggurat of Ur.

Ea-nasir: copper merchant of Ur, remembered for a customer's angry complaint tablet.

Ashurbanipal: Assyrian king who boasted that he could read; his library was found at Nineveh.

Hormuzd Rassam: born in Mosul in 1826; found more of the library in 1853.

Leonard Woolley: excavated Ur from 1922 to 1934.

Legend or history?

The Hanging Gardens of Babylon have never been found, and their location is still debated. The popular idea that ziggurats were observatories is not well supported, and the theory of "segmented sleep" in the past is still argued over. The episode keeps these apart from what the tablets and excavations show.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Learn more





Artistic impressions of a family asleep on a flat roof and of a scribe at lamplight, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

Books

Between Two Rivers: Ancient Mesopotamia and the Birth of History ↗, Moudhy Al-Rashid (W. W. Norton, 2025).

Babylon: Mesopotamia and the Birth of Civilization ↗, Paul Kriwaczek (Thomas Dunne, 2012).

Mesopotamia: The Invention of the City ↗, Gwendolyn Leick (Penguin, 2002).

The Epic of Gilgamesh ↗, trans. Andrew George (Penguin Classics).

The Ancient Near East: A Very Short Introduction ↗, Amanda H. Podany (Oxford University Press, 2013).

Ancient Assyria: A Very Short Introduction ↗, Karen Radner (Oxford University Press, 2015).

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Full reading list ↗

Museums & places

British Museum, London: the Ashurbanipal reliefs and the library tablets.

Penn Museum, Philadelphia: finds from Woolley's Ur, including the Enheduanna disk.

Institute for the Study of Ancient Cultures, Chicago.

Pergamon Museum, Berlin: the Ishtar Gate (check opening before you visit).

Podcasts

Thin End of the Wedge: experts on life in the ancient Middle East, in plain language.

In Our Time: Epic of Gilgamesh, BBC Radio 4 (2016).

"And over the wide, flat land, over the Tigris and the Euphrates, the moon, round and calm and silver, keeping its long, patient watch through the night."

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Dreaming Ages History · Narration is AI-generated text-to-speech; illustrations are AI-generated artistic impressions. Facts follow the episode script and its sources. Maps drawn from real coordinates: Natural Earth; historical borders simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset (A. Ourednik). Free for personal use. Sleep well. 🌙